

Learn to Be a Great Communicator: Pat in Her Own Words

Coach Pat Summitt

Communication is key. Communication on the floor. You know, we have a “rebound two points” philosophy. We make a mistake, they are to verbalize, “Rebound. Rebound from your mistake. Move on.” The mental training aspect of this game now is much needed.

You know, we’re not driving a car. If we’re driving a car, and if we don’t stop at the stop sign, we usually get pulled over if anybody catches us, right? Because we did something wrong. If we do stop at the stop sign, nobody ever says, “Good job.” When they do things on the court, they need to hear, “Good job.”

So, I’ve really tried to become a better communicator by becoming a better listener.

You communicate with your body language. You know, you see assistant coaches and you see them in the huddle -- and I have a wonderful staff. I would not have enjoyed the success that I’ve enjoyed without the people around me. And I just know that no matter what we talk about, they’re going to be right there with me. When you go into a huddle, coaches, you ever think about being a great leader and communicating what they need? It’s not about what you need.

I remember for the Vanderbilt game here, my outlet is, I have to exercise. I don’t like it. I just have to do it because I need an outlet. And that day, when I was working out, I thought, “Tonight, you’ve got to be in a really tough ballgame.” I communicated with myself and I said, “It’s going to be real important that you stay calm for the team.” And to get back to that afternoon, I just wanted to come to the gym and do everything within my power to help our team.

It’s not about you, it’s about them. I wanted them to be prepared. I wanted them to come to the huddle and even after a bad play, say, “That’s all right. We’re OK.” Because they watch you. You can be the barometer for that team. You can be the inspiration, or you can pull them down. This is bigger than any offense you’re going to run, in my opinion, is how you communicate with your players and how they perform and respond as a result.